

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, April 8, 2020, via Zoom.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:38 p.m.

Mayor Lovett read the following statement: *This meeting is being conducted in accordance with the provisions of the Governor's Executive Order no. 2020-04 and the emergency meeting provisions of RSA 91-A to permit participation of board members by electronic means. Under the conditions of the current COVID-19 pandemic and the protocols established by the Centers for Disease Control (CDC), it is not reasonably practical for a quorum of this board's members to attend this meeting in person.*

Reminder: Zoom participants press the mute button until you wish to speak.

Due to the COVID-19 Pandemic, the City is suggesting citizens participate in this meeting by conference phone. Please dial 1-800-875-3456 and request Claremont City Council Meeting. If there is a problem getting through to that number, please call 603-542-7002.

Members of the Council present were:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O'Hearne (in Chambers)
At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier (Zoom video)
At-Large Councilor Erica Sweetser (in Chambers)
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren (Zoom video)
Mayor Charlene Lovett (Zoom video)
At-Large Councilor Debora Matteau (Zoom video)
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski (in Chambers)
Ward II Councilor James Contois (Zoom video)
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone (in Chambers)

Also present:

Edward Morris, City Manager (Zoom video)

AGENDA CHANGES

None

REPORT OF THE SECRETARY

A motion was made by Ms. Matteau and seconded by Mr. Damren to accept the minutes of the March 5, 2020, City Council meeting, as amended.

Mayor Lovett said she was not at the meeting and that Assistant Mayor Damren called the meeting to order. Also, the vote for adjournment should be 8-0, not 7-0.

Mayor Lovett said she was not at the March 5th meeting, so she abstained.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - abstain

Motion carried 8-0, 1 abstain.

A motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Mr. Stone to accept the minutes of the March 11, 2020, City Council meeting.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - abstain

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 8-0, 1 abstain.

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Ms. Matteau to accept the minutes of the March 16, 2020, City Council meeting.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. Stone to accept the minutes of the March 25, 2020, City Council meeting, as amended.

Ms. Kier asked if the minutes should indicate who was physically present and who was on phone. Mr. Morris agreed.

Roll call vote:

O’Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

MAYOR’S NOTES

- Residents throughout the community are doing things to help their neighbor (i.e. resident making masks and distributing them to those who need them)
- Thank you to everyone for all they are doing
- It is critical for everyone to follow the CDC guidelines. She received emails from residents that many people are not following the guidelines. She requested that if you have a mask, to wear it to protect the citizens of Claremont.
- April 22 is Earth Day. Everyone can make a difference by picking up litter when out walking

Mr. Damren called out to all the personnel at the Sullivan County Nursing Home for helping people to keep in contact with their loved ones. Visits are not allowed, but staff are making sure that residents have FaceTime connections, and that family members can see their loved ones through the window and talk to them over the telephone.

Mr. Damren talked about the Love Local shirts which are available for order through the Greater Claremont Chamber of Commerce. Mayor Lovett said it is a partnership between the Chamber and the Ink Factory and \$10 of each sale will go to help local businesses.

Mr. Contois said he is the Ward 2 Councilor and he talked about the tragic fire that ended with a loss of life. He thanked Fire Chief Bryan Burr and the firefighters for their work.

CITY MANAGER’S REPORT

- **Fire** – On 4-2-2020 the fire department responded to a mobile home fire. After the fire was extinguished, a deceased male victim was located inside the structure. The fire is currently under investigation by the Fire Marshal’s office.

- **Smoke Detector Program** – Reminder to check smoke detectors. For those needing help affording them, contact the Fire Department.
- **Rail Trail** – The City is continuing to work with the State of NH and local landowners on the possibility of moving the Rail Trail behind 287-313 Washington Street.
- **147 Main Street** - NEPA review is complete, except for the final letter from the State Historic Preservation Office. Plans for the new wall have been submitted to the state. Under the circumstances, the state is not going to require a full memorandum of agreement pursuant to federal Section 106, but instead is going to be sending a letter requiring that what was agreed on locally be followed. Release of funds anticipated around May 4th.
- **Social Distancing** – The United States is expecting COVID-19 to cause the death of 100,000 to 200,000 people. He emphasized that people should take the Stay-at-Home Order and social distancing guidelines seriously.
- **Retooling Service Delivery** - City staff continues to try to maintain flexibility to provide services needed during these unprecedented times. This past week we have changed the service delivery of our Parks and Recreation and Library staff. On March 30th the full-time Parks and Recreation staff started assisting citizens with completion of SBA loan forms, and the Library staff has been helping people fill out unemployment forms. Both of these services are available by appointment. Library staff will also assist with submissions to help citizens receive their stimulus checks.
- The Transfer Station will be operating normal hours on Tuesdays and Saturdays; only four cars will be let in at a time.
- The Zoning Board of Adjustment (ZBA) meeting to discuss the recycling facility has been postponed.
- The City will host some ZBA meetings based on development need. Mr. Morris will review requests to determine which are essential.
- Regarding the closure of basketball courts, there is no plan to take down the hoops. Signs will be posted reminding players of the need for social distancing. If people don't comply, the hoops will be taken down.
- If someone sees businesses not adhering to the guidelines, they should contact the Police Department.
- Regarding the Section 8 Vouchers for the Goddard Block, Mr. Morris has not decided whether to sign the document yet, but he is leaning toward it.

APPOINTMENT TO BOARDS AND COMMITTEES

Tax Increment Finance District Advisory Board – Downtown

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Ms. Matteau to appoint Martha Maki to seat 1 (owner or occupant of real property located within or adjacent to the TIFD) of the Tax Increment Finance District Advisory Board – Downtown.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

A motion was made by Mr. Koloski and seconded by Mr. O’Hearne to appoint Derek Ferland to seat 4 (Member at Large) of the Tax Increment Finance District Advisory Board – Downtown.

Roll call vote:

O’Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

A motion was made by Ms. Matteau and seconded by Mr. Stone to appoint Robert Porter to seat 5 (Member at Large) of the Tax Increment Finance District Advisory Board – Downtown.

Roll call vote:

O’Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

CITIZEN’S FORUM

No one spoke.

OLD BUSINESS

COVID-19 Update

Mr. Morris said as of today, 747 people in NH have tested positive for COVID-19. The number of new cases per day have been in the 40s. NH deaths are at 13 (2%). He asked people to continue social distancing. City Hall is still open via the Opera House Square entrance. The Assessing and City Manager's offices are open for people with questions. There is a Drop Box at Central Collections for payments. People are in all the offices taking phone calls. Any City paperwork can be dropped in the Drop Box. Applications for Planning and Development can be sent to that office. The Claremont Savings Bank Community Center (CSBCC) and the Library are closed. Public Works is still open, with a smaller crew.

Mr. Morris said the Dartmouth surge site MOU (Memorandum of Understanding) has been signed and they will be setting that up with the National Guard soon. On the County and City website, there is a nonprofit funding form, funded through Dartmouth Hitchcock for non-profits to request assistance. People who wish, can donate.

Mr. Morris said through May 4th, the City is expecting revenue loss from the CSBCC of about \$88,000. Also, property taxes and water/sewer payments may be delayed. He is working with Interim Assessor Stephen Hamilton on the Governor's Emergency Order allowing abatements. There will be shortfalls in the Rooms and Meals tax revenues (hotels closed and restaurants only able to offer takeout or delivery). Expecting 10% loss in Highway Block Grant Revenue. Expecting delays in motor vehicle registrations, maybe even fewer vehicle purchases. The City is estimating a potential revenue shortfall for FY21 of \$630,000. There is still one employee being isolated from a potential exposure.

Mr. Morris will make sure CDC guidelines are posted on the City's website.

Ms. Kier said everyone should wear face coverings when around other people.

Mayor Lovett said her understanding is that the municipality will be reimbursed for losses tied to COVID-19. Mr. Morris said things like laptops to work from home and extra PPE will be reimbursed, but as of now, there is nothing that will cover revenue shortfalls. Mayor Lovett said this needs to be brought up with the Governor and Mr. Morris agreed. Mayor Lovett said the next phase will be recovery.

i. Discussion of Process to Report Scams and Price Gouging

Mayor Lovett said the DOJ has set up a taskforce to stop price gouging, etc. (go to the DOJ website to see what they've uncovered). Reports can be made online and through local law enforcement. Office of Inspector General is warning the public about Social Security scams.

Mr. Koloski talked about bogus websites for SBA loans, it would be best to go through SBA.org; and for paycheck protection loans, it would be best to go to a bank that you are familiar with.

Mr. Morris said if anyone gets a suspicious letter, they can report it to their local police department.

ii. Discussion of State Resources Network

Mayor Lovett said the resources network is made up of regional, state and federal level. She is a member of the regional level. They are trying to match resources with needs. To help with that effort, she is compiling a list of volunteers; volunteers can send information to her. Mr. Koloski said a local need is that the Soup Kitchen donations are down. Mayor Lovett said a member of the coalition should have contacted the Soup Kitchen today.

NEW BUSINESS

Resolution 2020-20 Airport Apron Project Grant – Public Hearing

WHEREAS the City is undertaking an Airport Apron Project at the Claremont Municipal Airport (the "Airport"); and

WHEREAS the City of Claremont, NH, has been approved for funding for the Airport Apron Project. SBG-02-13-2020 Phase I Grant (Design, Permit, Bid and Technical Observation of Construction) for said project in the amount of \$218,000.00 and;

WHEREAS the City would like to now accept and expend said funds;

NOW THEREFORE BE IT RESOLVED to raise, appropriate and expend the sum of \$218,000.00 with \$196,200.00 (90%) to come from the Federal Aviation Administration, \$10,900.00 (5%) to come from the NH Department of Transportation Bureau of Aeronautics, and the remaining \$10,900.00 (5%) as our local match to be taken from the Airport Reserve Account (to have no impact on the tax rate); and

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED that the City Manager or his designees are hereby authorized to execute all documents and undertake all actions as may be required to implement this resolution. *(2/3 Vote Required)*

Fire Chief Bryan Burr gave some background. The project is expected to start in the summer of 2020.

He said he will come back to the Council for phase 2 and he expects there will be a 5% local match.

A motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Mr. O’Hearne to adopt Resolution 2020-20 Airport Apron Project Grant.

Ms. Kier read the resolution into the record.

Mayor Lovett opened the public hearing. No one spoke. She closed it.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Mr. Damren said Council needs to discuss the budget work sessions (i.e. an all-day session or multiple evenings).

Mr. Contois said Council needs to discuss not meeting in Council Chambers – to lead by example. Mayor Lovett said there is technology to do this completely remotely. For those who need access to the internet, they can have access to one of the office spaces. She agreed this should be done remotely.

Ms. Kier agreed. She said at DHMC (Dartmouth Hitchcock Medical Center) all employees have to wear masks and all meetings are telemeetings. It is important to listen to CDC guidelines. It is important to keep Councilors and staff safe.

Mr. Koloski said he has no problem transitioning everyone to meeting remotely, but someone has to be here to deal with people calling in on the conference phone. Mr. Morris said the City is working on that with our conference call company, and it will be a better system overall.

Ms. Sweetser agreed with the need to take precautions, but she sees nurses, doctors and grocery store clerks showing up to work, so if she can show up here safely, she'll do it.

Mr. O'Hearne said he has heard about public meetings being hacked, so he asked what the City Manager is doing to prevent that. Mr. Morris said that because of the threats, we're looking at a private company; we are looking at the security part.

Mr. O'Hearne agreed with Ms. Sweetser; if you respect social distancing and wear a mask, he feels he should be able to show up in Council Chambers.

Ms. Kier pointed out that none of the Councilors in Council Chambers were wearing masks, as recommended by CDC guidelines. Mayor Lovett said Councilors need to lead by example. She said she wears a mask when out.

Ms. Matteau agreed that the guideline for wearing a mask is a smart one to follow. Also, that it would be easier for the Mayor to run the meeting if all Councilors were on Zoom.

Mayor Lovett said the plan for future meetings is for everyone who elects to do so, to participate via Zoom, and for those who want to go to City Hall, to coordinate with the City Manager.

Mr. Morris said he is planning to invite the auditors to the next Council meeting. It is a non-voting issue; it is important to hear about the audit before the budget discussions begin. They will be in on the video conference. There were no objections.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

ADJOURNMENT

At 7:40 p.m., a motion was made by Mr. O’Hearne and seconded by Ms. Sweetser to adjourn.

Roll call vote:

O’Hearne - yes

Kier - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council